



Parents and Carers · Secondary · Session 4

Home and Community

Distress and unmet needs

What we see is often only the tip of the iceberg.

Behaviour

What we can see and hear.

Underneath

Thoughts and feelings, values, and needs such as belonging, predictability, security and self-expression.

A reaction is rarely a choice. It usually makes sense once we understand what came before: an unexpected change, too much noise, a demand that was too big on that day.

Behaviour is communication. Be curious about what sits underneath.

Overwhelm

Shutdown

Turning inward. Freeze or flop. Less able to speak or say what they need. Can be hidden or masked.

Meltdown

Turning outward. Fight or flight. Might look like crying, running away or a big emotional outburst.

These are involuntary responses to overwhelm, not a choice.

When overwhelm builds up

Autistic burnout

Deep physical, mental and emotional exhaustion after a long time of too much sensory and social demand. Skills and capacity can drop for a while.

School Can't

Not being able to go to school because of overwhelming anxiety, fear or sensory overload. It is not a choice or defiance.

Burnout and School Can't are often signs that a young person has been coping with more than we realised, for longer than we realised. Looking underneath helps us find the support, adjustments and recovery they need.

What can help in the moment?

Be curious, not judgemental.

Reduce input: fewer words, fewer questions, less noise.

Have a safe, quiet space you have agreed on before.

Remember it is a body response. They are doing the best they can.

Talking it through can wait until they are calm.

Self-regulation and co-regulation

Co-regulation

A calm, trusted adult helps your young person settle. Your steady presence does a lot of the work. Teenagers still need this, even when they push away.

Self-regulation

What your young person does to manage their own energy and feelings. It grows over time, with support.

Co-regulation comes first. Self-regulation builds from it.

The after-school crash in the teenage years

Many Autistic young people hold it together at school and let go at home.

Recovery first

Food, quiet, movement or screen time, their choice, before any questions or demands.

Talk later

"How was school?" can wait. They may tell you later, often late in the evening, or not at all.

Homework can wait too

Straight after school, the battery is often empty.

Keep it the same

A simple after-school routine they can rely on.

Homework and assessment at home

Starting and planning are often the hardest parts, not the work itself.

Help with the start

Sit with them for the first step, or agree what the first step is.

Make the timeline visible

Due dates on a calendar or wall planner, with the steps in between.

Break it down

Smaller chunks with a clear finish for each one.

Talk to school

If the load is too much, ask about adjustments. That is what they are for.

Interests are an anchor

Regulation

Time with an interest can restore energy faster than almost anything else.

Connection

Their interest is a way in. Connection often starts inside their world.

Joy and identity

Deep interests are part of who they are, not something to ration.

Taking an interest away as a consequence often makes regulation harder.

Growing independence

In small steps

Build independence one step at a time, with support that fades as confidence grows.

Talk about risk together

Agree what feels safe enough, and what happens if it does not go to plan.

Home as a safe base

The teenage years bring a changing identity. Home can be the place they can be fully themselves.

Sleep and screens

Sleep matters

Tiredness lowers everyone's capacity. Many Autistic young people have trouble with sleep.

Screens do many jobs

Rest, regulation, connection and interests, as well as the things we worry about.

Honest trade-offs

Work out together what matters most for your family right now, and review it.

One step towards independence

Think of one thing your young person could do more independently.

- 1 What is it? Catching a bus, cooking a meal, managing money, contacting a teacher...
- 2 What is the first small step?
- 3 What support stays in place, and how will you review it together?
- 4 Share one idea with your table.

Your own battery counts

It helps your young person

It is hard to help someone else stay calm when you are running on empty.

Small and daily

Ten minutes, a walk, a cup of tea in peace, asking for help.

Your supports

A partner, family, friends, other parents. The people in this room are one of them.

Looking after yourself is part of looking after your family.

Let's share what works

Families know a lot. Share one thing that works in your home.

- 1 Mornings, after school, homework, sleep, screens or your own battery.
- 2 Each person shares one idea with the table.
- 3 Write down one idea you would like to try.